UHF/VHF Ham Radio Cheat Sheet

by Dan Tennery-Spalding, K6XCX

General Radio Etiquette

1. Listen and wait for a pause in radio traffic before talking. (transmitting)
2. Hold down the push-to-talk (PTT) button and *wait 1 second* because your radio's transmitter may take that long to kick in.
   a. Hold down the PTT button firmly for as long as you are speaking.
   b. No one else can transmit while you are transmitting, so…
   c. Say one thing only each time you transmit. *Don't ramble*.
3. Say the name of who you're calling 2-3 times, and then your own.
4. When you are done, say "Over" to indicate the other side can talk.
5. To break into a conversation, say "Break" and your name during a pause.
   a. Say "Priority" if it's urgent, "Emergency" if it's an emergency.
6. Acknowledge the other side's transmission with "Copy" or "Roger".
7. When your conversation is over, say your name and then "Clear" to indicate that you're leaving the channel open for others to use.

Repeater Etiquette

A repeater is a shared resource for many radio operators. Keep conversations brief! Move longer conversations off the repeater ASAP.

1. Follow all the general radio etiquette rules!
2. Wait an extra second before talking; some repeaters have a courtesy tone you can hear that tells you when you can start talking.
3. State your FCC callsign at the beginning of your first transmission.
4. If necessary, exchange contact info with the person you're talking to: a non-repeater GMRS channel, a phone number, even a meeting place.
5. When you finish, release the PTT button and listen for the repeater to make the tone that says your transmission was successfully received.
6. Wait an extra second before speaking again, to give time for others to transmit to the repeater if they need to break in.

Alfa	**E**cho	**I**ndia	**M**ike	**Q**uebec	**U**niform	**Y**ankee
Bravo	**F**oxtrot	**J**uliett	**N**ovember	**R**omeo	**V**ictor	**Z**ulu
Charlie	**G**olf	**K**ilo	**O**scar	**S**ierra	**W**hiskey	
Delta	**H**otel	**L**ima	**P**apa	**T**ango	**X**-Ray	

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If You Can’t Hear or Reach Others

1. Confirm you are on the right channel and privacy tone, if any.
2. Ensure the antenna isn’t blocked by your body or anything else.
3. Move away from metal, concrete, earthen hills, etc.
4. Check that your battery has power, that the antenna is screwed in, the microphone and/or speaker aren’t dirty or clogged, etc.
5. Check your settings: Volume, transmit power (you usually want “high” or equivalent), and squelch level (it may be set too high)
6. Move higher (“height is might”) and try for line of sight your contact.

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